being a "meat-eating and alcohol-accepting goddess" at the India Today Conclave East in July 2022, the BJP, expectedly, raised a firestorm over it. Sensing that a narrative could be spun involving Bengal's revered goddess, the TMC promptly dissociated itself from Moitra's views. "The comments made by Mahua Moitra...is (*sic*) not endorsed by the party in any manner or form," it said in a statement. The party also engaged veteran leaders like Saugata Roy to say in clear terms that "it was unacceptable to us". Moitra was thus left alone to fight her battle against trolls on social media. If she had hoped that her party, which once advocated free speech and liberalism, would openly back her, she was in for a disappointment. The Trinamool leadership saw in it the potential of the BJP running away with the narrative that such statements were offensive to Hinduism.

And with the 2024 general election drawing near, the BJP has only upped its game. Its supporters continue to irk the chief minister with 'Jai Shri Ram' slogans at every opportunity, like at the inauguration of the Vande Bharat Express on December 30. In addition, BJP state president Sukanta Majumdar and Adhikary are organising protest rallies. The BJP also plans to take out raths across the state. Mediated through religious imagery and statements, political temperatures are rising in Bengal. Yet, even as the TMC is at pains to project itself as far removed from the saffron party's allegedly aggressive brand of Hindutva, it gets drawn into a competition with it. Along with statements and symbolic gestures, there is also a demonstration of intent. And it's driven by none other than the CM herself. For now, temples and rituals are at the forefront.

THE GRAND TEMPLE RUN

The West Bengal government began constructing new temples and promoting religious tourism as a new sector from 2020. That year, it allocated Rs 65 crore for building the Rani Rashmoni skywalk connecting the Dakshineswar railway station to the famous Kali temple compound. A similar revamp of the Tarapeeth Kali temple in Birbhum, the Tarakeswar Shiva temple and the Hansweswari temple in Hooghly was announced. In 2022, Mamata budgeted Rs 300 crore for a revamp of the Kalighat temple in Kolkata.

In 2019-20, Mamata took the decision to construct a Jagannath temple on 10 acres of land in the beach town of Digha, and set aside Rs 500 crore for it in the 2022-23 budget. The decision did come soon after the BJP's emergence as the principal opposition, but there's another interesting backstory to it. On a visit to the Puri Jagannath temple in 2017, Mamata faced angry priests, who accused her of supporting the consumption of beef. A miffed Mamata is said to have resolved to build Bengal's own version. The land at Digha has been arranged by the Digha-Shankarpur Development Authority (DSDA), the nodal authority for infrastructure development. Plans of economic regeneration in the area, revolving around the temple, have been drawn up, and shops and stalls are on sale for Rs 1 lakh. The authorities hope to complete the project before 2026, the year of the next state election.

Another replica is the Vaishno Devi temple, construction for which is complete. It has come up on an acre of land in Kolkata's Behala. The entire area now has eight temples for deities that have well-known temples dedicated to them in Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh, be it Jeen Mata, Rani Sati, goddesses Sitala, Bhairon Nath, Khatu Shyam or Radha-Krishna. TMC mayor-in-council Tarak Singh is arranging funds by roping in

TMC'S COSTLY TEMPLE SPREE

₹65 CRORE
Dakshineswar skywalk

₹300 CRORE
Revamp of Kolkata's Kalighat temple

₹500 CRORE
Construction of Jagannath temple in Digha

Shakti Peethas in Bengal being developed and beautified

₹50 LAKH
spent on Vaishnodevi Temple and eight other temples in Behala, Kolkata

OVER ₹1 CRORE
Five new temples resembling the Kalighat, Tarapeeth, Johura Kali, Dakshineswar and Tarakeswar temples in Gangasagar

